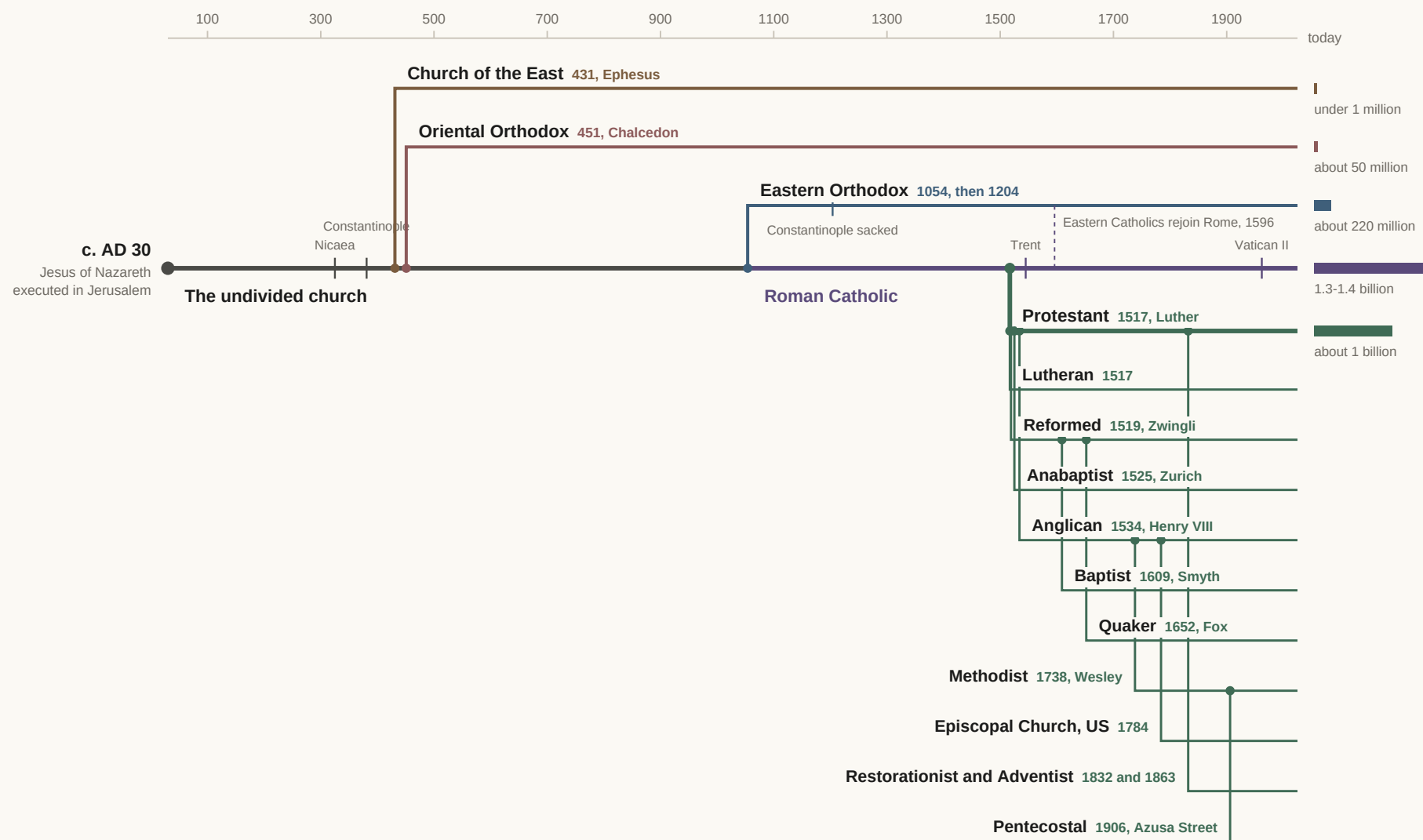
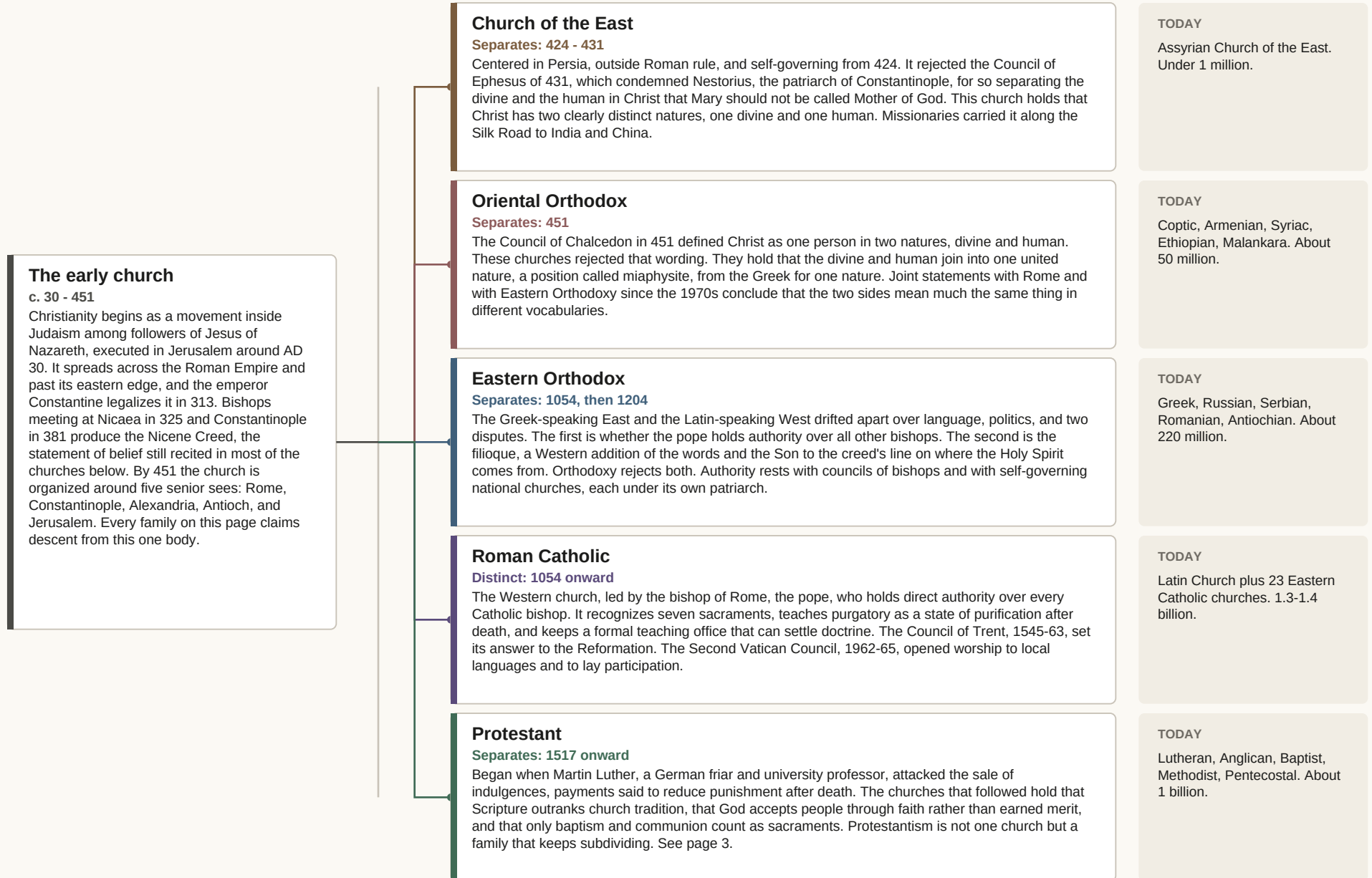


Christianity: Two Thousand Years of Branching



Baptists and Quakers grew out of English Separatism, which was Reformed in theology, and Baptists also drew on Mennonite practice in Amsterdam. Pentecostalism came through the Holiness movement, which was Methodist. Restorationist and Adventist bodies drew on several streams at once, so they branch from the Protestant trunk rather than from any single parent. The scale is even from AD 30 to today, and the bar for the Church of the East is too small to register against the others.

The Five Main Families



The 1054 date is a convenience. Rome and Constantinople drifted apart over centuries, and the mutual excommunications issued that year were lifted in 1965. The sack of Constantinople by Western crusaders in 1204 did more lasting damage than the paperwork did.

The Protestant Branch

Lutheran

1517 - 1530

Martin Luther, an Augustinian friar teaching at Wittenberg, posted 95 arguments against indulgences on October 31, 1517. He held that Scripture alone binds the conscience and that God accepts people through faith, not merit. The Augsburg Confession of 1530 set out the position. Lutheran churches keep liturgy, vestments, and the belief that Christ is truly present in the bread and wine.

Reformed

1519 - 1536

Huldrych Zwingli began reforming Zurich in 1519. John Calvin, a French lawyer living in exile in Geneva, published the Institutes of the Christian Religion in 1536. Both stripped worship back to preaching and Scripture and removed images from churches. Calvin taught that God elects, or chooses, who is saved. Boards of elders govern the churches; there are no bishops.

Anglican

1534 - 1571

Henry VIII broke with Rome in 1534 to obtain an annulment, not over doctrine. Thomas Cranmer, his archbishop, supplied the theology through the Book of Common Prayer of 1549, which gave English worship a single form still in use. The Thirty-Nine Articles followed in 1571. Bishops and sacraments remain, and unity rests on praying together rather than on signing a doctrinal statement.

Radical Reformation (Anabaptist)

1525

In January 1525 a group in Zurich baptized one another as adults, arguing that infant baptism does not count because faith cannot be inherited. Opponents called them Anabaptists, meaning rebaptizers. They held that the church is a voluntary body of believers that the state has no business running, and many refused oaths and military service. Catholic and Protestant authorities executed them in large numbers. Their descendants include the Mennonites, named for the Dutch leader Menno Simons, and the Amish, who separated in 1693 under Jakob Ammann.

LATER MOVEMENTS

Baptist

1609

John Smyth, an English separatist exiled in Amsterdam, baptized himself and his congregation as believing adults in 1609. Baptists hold that baptism follows a personal decision, that each congregation governs itself, and that no creed binds it.

Congregational and Quaker

1580s and 1652

English separatists under Robert Browne rejected bishops outright from the 1580s; their descendants founded Plymouth Colony. George Fox's Quakers, from 1652, went further and dropped clergy and sacraments, meeting in silence until someone speaks.

Methodist

1738 - 1795

John Wesley, an Anglican priest, led a revival built on personal holiness, lay preaching, and hymns written largely by his brother Charles. American Methodists organized separately in 1784, the British in 1795, after Wesley's death in 1791.

Episcopal Church (US)

1784 - 1789

After independence, American Anglicans could no longer swear loyalty to the British crown. Samuel Seabury was consecrated bishop in Scotland in 1784, and the church adopted a constitution and its own prayer book at the 1789 General Convention.

Adventist and Restorationist

1832 - 1863

Movements that set aside later church history and tried to rebuild the first-century church from Scripture alone. The Stone-Campbell churches merged in 1832. Seventh-day Adventists, who keep Saturday as the Sabbath, organized in 1863.

Pentecostal

1901 - 1906

Began with students in Topeka, Kansas, in 1901 and spread from William Seymour's Azusa Street revival in Los Angeles in 1906. Teaches a second experience after conversion, baptism in the Holy Spirit, marked by speaking in tongues and by healing.

Latter-day Saints, founded in 1830, and Jehovah's Witnesses, organized from the 1870s, are usually charted apart from Protestantism. Both reject the doctrine of the Trinity set out at Nicaea, which every family on page 2 shares.

Key Differences at a Glance

	FINAL AUTHORITY	BREAD AND WINE	HOW SALVATION WORKS	MINISTRY	WORSHIP
Roman Catholic	Scripture and tradition, interpreted by the pope and the bishops	Transubstantiation: the bread and wine become Christ's body and blood while still appearing to be bread and wine	Grace received through the sacraments; faith and works together	Bishops in unbroken succession from the apostles; celibate priests in the Latin Church	Fixed liturgy, the Mass, seven sacraments
Eastern Orthodox	Scripture and tradition, settled by the seven councils held from 325 to 787	A real change, deliberately left undefined	Theosis: a lifelong process of being remade in God's likeness	Bishops in succession; parish priests may marry before ordination	The Divine Liturgy, icons, unaccompanied singing
Oriental Orthodox	Scripture and the first three councils only: 325, 381, 431	A real change, left undefined	Theosis, as in Eastern Orthodoxy	Bishops in succession, each church under its own patriarch	Ancient rites in Coptic, Ge'ez, Armenian, and Syriac
Church of the East	Scripture and the first two councils only: 325 and 381	A real presence, with its own ancient eucharistic prayer	God's grace working together with human effort	Bishops in succession under a catholicos, their senior bishop	East Syriac rite, sung in a dialect of Aramaic
Lutheran	Scripture alone, read alongside the historic creeds	Christ truly present in, with, and under the bread and wine	Faith alone; good works follow from it but do not earn it	Ordained pastors; bishops in some national churches	Liturgical, with a strong hymn tradition
Reformed and Presbyterian	Scripture alone, as the only binding rule	Christ present spiritually, received by faith	Faith alone; God elects who is saved	Elders and ministers govern together; bishops rare	Built around preaching, plain in style
Anglican and Episcopal	Scripture first, weighed with tradition and reason	A real presence, deliberately not defined	Faith alone, worked out through the sacraments	Bishops in succession; women ordained in most provinces	The Book of Common Prayer, choral tradition
Baptist	Scripture alone, read by each congregation for itself	A symbol and a memorial, not a change	Faith alone, professed publicly in adult baptism	Pastors called and dismissed by the congregation	Non-liturgical, built around the sermon
Methodist	Scripture, weighed with tradition, reason, and experience	A real presence; anyone may receive	Faith alone, followed by growth toward holiness	Ordained elders; bishops in some bodies	Liturgical roots, driven by hymns
Pentecostal	Scripture, plus the Spirit speaking in the present	A symbol and a memorial	Faith and conversion, then baptism in the Spirit	Pastors, often without formal training	Spontaneous, music-led, gifts of the Spirit

The seven sacraments are baptism, confirmation, the Eucharist, penance, anointing of the sick, ordination, and marriage. Most Protestant churches count only baptism and the Eucharist, on the grounds that Scripture records Jesus instituting those two.

Key Dates

325	Council of Nicaea Condemns Arius, who taught that the Son was created by the Father rather than eternal with him.	1534	Act of Supremacy Parliament makes Henry VIII head of the English church, ending papal jurisdiction in England.
381	Council of Constantinople Adds the section on the Holy Spirit and completes the creed still recited in most of these churches.	1545-1563	Council of Trent Rome defines its doctrine against the Reformers and overhauls the training and conduct of clergy.
431	Council of Ephesus Condemns Nestorius over how the divine and human join in Christ. The Church of the East does not follow.	1549	Book of Common Prayer Thomas Cranmer gives English worship one vernacular form, still the basis of Anglican liturgy.
451	Council of Chalcedon Defines Christ as one person in two natures. The Oriental Orthodox reject the wording and separate.	1609	First Baptist congregation John Smyth baptizes believing adults in Amsterdam, giving believer's baptism organized form.
787	Second Council of Nicaea Ends the first campaign against religious images. The last council both East and West accept.	1738	Wesley's conversion John Wesley's experience at a London meeting begins the Methodist movement inside Anglicanism.
1054	Mutual excommunications Envoys of Pope Leo IX and Patriarch Michael Cerularius excommunicate each other in Constantinople.	1789	Episcopal Church constituted American Anglicans adopt a constitution and their own prayer book after independence.
1204	Sack of Constantinople Crusaders bound for Egypt take the city instead and install a Latin ruler for nearly sixty years.	1870	First Vatican Council Defines that the pope teaches without error when ruling formally on faith and morals.
1378-1417	Western Schism Rival popes in Rome and Avignon claim the office at once, discrediting the papacy and inviting reform.	1906	Azusa Street revival William Seymour's revival in Los Angeles turns Pentecostalism into a global movement.
1517	Luther's 95 Theses Academic objections to the sale of indulgences circulate in print and become a rupture within months.	1962-1965	Second Vatican Council Mass in local languages, openness to other churches, and a larger role for lay people.
1525	Zurich adult baptisms Adults are rebaptized in Zurich, beginning the Radical Reformation and its rejection of state churches.	1965	Excommunications lifted Paul VI and Athenagoras revoke the mutual condemnations of 1054.

NOTES

The creed. The text called the Nicene Creed is traditionally credited to the councils of 325 and 381, and this chart follows that convention. The full text first appears in the record at Chalcedon in 451, so the attribution to 381 is traditional rather than documented.

Population figures. The totals are approximate and depend on how you count. Baptismal registers favor Catholic and Orthodox numbers; survey self-identification favors Protestant ones. The World Christian Database at Gordon-Conwell, 2025, gives 1.27 billion Catholics, 639 million Protestants, 426 million Independents, and 292 million Orthodox, that last figure combining Eastern and Oriental. The Vatican's 2025 yearbook reports 1.406 billion baptized Catholics through 2023. Pew Research Center puts Protestants, broadly defined, at roughly 37 percent of all Christians.

Eastern Catholic churches. These use Eastern liturgies while remaining in communion with Rome, and belong on the Catholic branch rather than the Orthodox one. Some came from reunions: the Ukrainian Greek Catholic Church traces to the Union of Brest in 1596, the largest of them. The Maronite Church of Lebanon has no history of separation from Rome at all.